

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Lightning

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

When you hear thunder, move into a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle immediately. There is no safe place outdoors during a thunderstorm. Wait at least 30 minutes after the last thunder before going back out.

Do now.

**Leave exposed areas**

01

Get out of water and off ridges, fields and beaches. Do not shelter beneath a lone tree.

**Choose real shelter**

02

Use a building or enclosed hard-top vehicle; picnic shelters and tents are not adequate.

**Avoid indoor pathways**

03

Stay away from showers, sinks, corded phones and plugged-in equipment.

**Help a struck person**

04

Call emergency services. A lightning victim carries no electrical charge; give CPR if needed and follow dispatcher instructions.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Choose a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle now. A tent, tree or open-sided shelter is not protective. If no shelter is available, reduce exposure while moving toward one; there is no outdoor posture that makes lightning safe.

Watch for.

Lightning can strike beyond rainfall. Do not wait for rain to seek shelter.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: leave exposed areas. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Lightning can strike beyond rainfall. Do not wait for rain to seek shelter.

Keep essentials within reach.

For lightning, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Choose a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle now. A tent, tree or open-sided shelter is not protective. If no shelter is available, reduce exposure while moving toward one; there is no outdoor posture that makes lightning safe. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Check forecasts before outdoor activity and identify shelter before leaving it.

First decision: Leave exposed areas

Get out of water and off ridges, fields and beaches. Do not shelter beneath a lone tree. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Choose a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle now. A tent, tree or open-sided shelter is not protective. If no shelter is available, reduce exposure while moving toward one; there is no outdoor posture that makes lightning safe. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Lightning can strike beyond rainfall. Do not wait for rain to seek shelter. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

When you hear thunder, move into a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle immediately. There is no safe place outdoors during a thunderstorm. Wait at least 30 minutes after the last thunder before going back out. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For lightning, keep the specific hazard in view: Lightning can strike beyond rainfall. Do not wait for rain to seek shelter.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Help a struck person. Call emergency services. A lightning victim carries no electrical charge; give CPR if needed and follow dispatcher instructions. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Lightning · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/lightning>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/lightning/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.